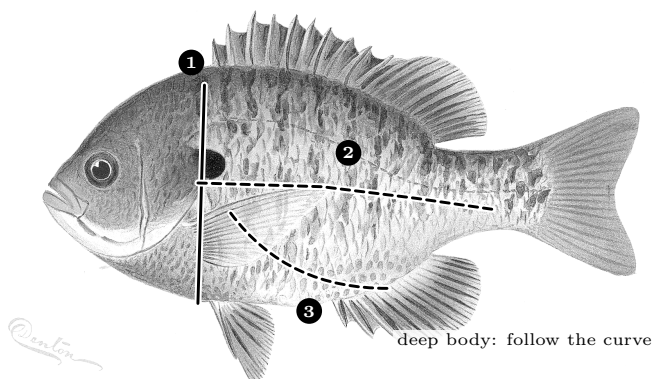


Cooking Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus — in the kitchen

The fish most people learn to clean on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Sweet, delicate and white. Slightly softer than perch but every bit as good, and there are usually a lot more of them.
Texture	Fine and tender. It will fall apart if you handle it roughly in the pan — that is the only difficulty.
Best size	8 in and up to fillet. Below that, pan-dress. A 9 in bluegill is a trophy and a superb meal.
Yield	Poor — about 22%. The deep body shape means a lot of fish becomes a little fillet. Budget three or four fish per person.
Ethics	June bed fish are the easiest to catch and the ones the population needs. Take a meal, not a cooler. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Freezing	Freeze in a block of water rather than dry — delicate flesh burns quickly in a freezer.

Filleting a deep-bodied fish

1. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the curve of the gill cover down and around, to the backbone.
2. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. On a deep-bodied fish the backbone sits high — roughly halfway up — so aim higher than feels right.
3. **Take the ribs** with a shallow arc, or cut the whole belly section away.
4. **Skin it** from the tail end. Bluegill skin releases easily.
5. **Or pan-dress:** scale it with the back of a knife against the grain, gut it, cut the head off behind the gills, trim the fins. Cook whole. For fish under about 8 in this is both faster and gives more food.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	The dorsal spines are sharp. Trim the whole spiny dorsal off first with kitchen shears — it makes the rest safer and quicker.
Rib cage	Fine and easy to lift out.
No pin bones	A bluegill fillet is clean once the ribs are out.
Pan-dressed	The whole skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking. Teach a child to do this and they will eat fish for life.

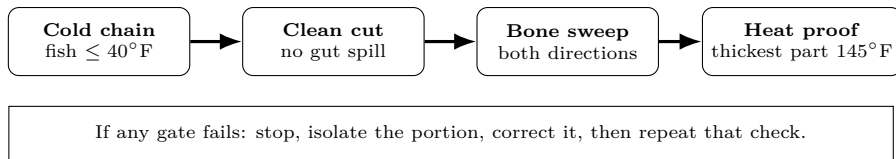
Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, then fine cornmeal with salt and cayenne. Hot oil, two minutes a side. The classic and still the best.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored twice on each side, floured, shallow-fried until crisp. Eat everything except the spine.
Bluegill cakes	For a big catch of small fish. Poach the fillets, flake, bind with egg, breadcrumbs, spring onion and mustard. Fry as patties. This is what to do with a hundred small ones.

The teaching fish

Bluegill is the right fish to learn knife work on: there are lots of them, they are cheap to ruin, and the anatomy is simple and obvious. Let a teenager fillet six badly before you correct anything. The seventh will be fine, and they will have learnt more than any amount of watching.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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